provided for prior notification if exercises involving more than one brigade (5,000 troops) were to take place. This would include date of completion of the exercise and de-induction of the troops involved.

At the same time, the 1993 agreement to jointly check and determine segments of the LAC with differing perceptions was upgraded to a shared objective of speeding up the process of clarification and confirmation of the LAC. Not just that, there were subsequently detailed understandings in 2005 and 2013 on handling situations of friction, if they were to arise.

In the years that passed, we obviously did not make significant progress on arriving at a common understanding of the alignment of the LAC in the India–China border areas. The appointment of Special Representatives (SRs) in 2003 did intensify the engagement, not just on the boundary question but on the larger relationship as well. A specific mechanism was also established in 2012 to address issues pertaining to the border areas. But all the while, there was also increasing construction of border infrastructure and depth-area logistics on the Chinese side. In contrast, the belief then in India was that our own border areas were best left undeveloped. This turned out to be a serious misjudgement that has cost us dearly.

Since 2014, there have been better efforts by India to reduce this very considerable infrastructure gap that had developed over three decades. Greater commitments raised the budget to four times the previous level. A better road-building record, which doubled construction and tripled tunnelling, was also indicative of improvement. Nevertheless, the infrastructure differential remains significant and, as we have seen in 2020, consequential. It, therefore, takes considerable operational ingenuity to make up for the lapses of the previous decades.

For all the differences and disagreements India and China may have had on the boundary, the central fact was that border areas remained fundamentally peaceful between 1975 and 2020. That is why the events in Galwan have so profoundly disturbed the relationship. They signalled a disregard for commitments about minimizing troop levels, informing about their deployment and movement, and respecting the status quo. The combination of these steps heightened the associated risks of breaching peace and tranquillity, with the results that we all know well by now. The impact this has had on both public and political opinions in India has been profound.